

watches—or even phony gold jewelry and watches—in a safe-deposit box in the United States. Carry only a small amount of cash in your sock or money belt and you won't have any problem. While walking along the Copacabana sidewalk one evening, I was accosted by two lovely young pickpockets masquerading as whores. Instead of panicking, I relaxed and enjoyed their physical overtures. I had nothing in my pockets, so a pickpocket posed little danger.

Vicki and I sometimes sit in a Copacabana sidewalk café and watch transvestites, prostitutes, beggars, pickpockets, and any combination of the above at work. If you're uncomfortable taking in the action on the sidewalk, head for the Ouro Verde hotel. The bar there has a small outdoor area protected by plants. You can sit behind the plants, sip a *caipirinha*, and watch the action in private.

SPAIN

Spain can best be thought of as several smaller countries united by a government that they all hate. To see Spain you need a "See Spain" pass from Iberia Airlines. The pass offers sixty days of unlimited air travel within Spain for only \$200. (Chapter 8 explains how to get a "See Spain" pass or a similar pass in other countries.)

Four hundred years ago Spain controlled the high seas. Spanish settlers colonized the New World. The Spanish flag flew over most of Europe, and Spanish culture was at its highest level. Except for the Rome of a thousand years before, Spain had the greatest empire in history. Yet, the Spanish empire declined. Historians are still puzzled as to how it happened.

I think I've found the answer.

Spain lost control of its empire because Spaniards failed to agree on how to run it. The fact is that, left to their own devices, Spaniards fail to agree on anything.

The problem is that Spaniards are firmly convinced that all